POST WAR HEAD- AND HEARTACHES

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The primary trouble with installing military-grade reflex governors in a human nervous system, Marcus had long concluded, was that the machinery never quite accepted the concept of peacetime.

A normal human brain, when exposed to a rainy evening on Nimbus, understands that a neon noodle stall is just a place where tired mechanics buy bowls of hot broth. The reflex implant wired into Marcus's spine, however, had been built during the worst eighteen months of the Kazahn campaign, when the Orkish Empire was dropping armored shock walkers into the frozen mud every few days. The implant did not understand soup. It understood muzzle flashes, shock waves, and flying iron. When a wet metal sign swung in the mountain wind with a rusty screech, his nerves didn't register an advertisement for dumplings; they registered an incoming mortar shell, sending a jolt of panic through his muscles and telling his hands to break something before it broke him.

Marcus exhaled slowly, his boots planted on the wet steel of the Level Eighty-Four skywalk. He counted to four. *Inhale.* He counted to four. *Exhale.*

"You're drifting, Sergeant," a voice said from his left.

Marcus didn't turn his head. If you looked at Corporal Aris, Aris vanished, and Marcus preferred him where he was. Aris was leaning his elbows on the safety rail, looking out over the two-mile drop of purple and gold clouds churning beneath Cloudspire. Aris was nineteen, smelled of burnt engine oil and cheap tobacco, and still wore his mud-caked combat webbing. Through the ragged hole in the center of Aris's chest rig, Marcus could see the blue neon glare of an insurance billboard across the way.

"I'm not drifting," Marcus whispered under the steady hiss of the rain. "I'm watching the crossing."

"Crossing's clear," Aris muttered, flicking a phantom cigarette butt into the clouds. "You got two snipers up on the crane towers, though. Orks. See them?"

Marcus looked up toward the thick steel cables stretching between the needle towers. No snipers. Just two city maintenance workers in yellow raincoats, tightening bolts against the wind.

"Workers," Marcus murmured. "Just maintenance."

"Sure," Aris said cheerfully. "And that drop-pod coming down through the clouds is just a weather balloon."

THUD.

A deep vibration hammered through the soles of his boots. The walkway shuddered. Overhead, the cloud deck flashed violet.

Marcus didn't think; his body dropped six inches and his hand swept under his coat for a heavy pistol that wasn't there. He had tossed the pistol into an industrial furnace three weeks ago, watching the steel melt because he couldn't trust his hands in the dark anymore.

His heart battered against his ribs like a trapped bird. He pressed his back against the pillar of a cab kiosk, his breath ragged, tasting copper and ozone.

In his mind, the towers of Cloudspire dissolved into the scarred trenches of the frontier. The rain wasn't clean water; it was the greasy stench of burning fuel and wet ashes. The sky tore open with fiery re-entry streaks. Orkish drop-cages—fourteen tons of stamped pig-iron with no parachutes and no mercy—screamed through the clouds on crude solid rockets, hitting the dirt with the sound of a falling cathedral. From the smoking wreckage rose two-legged iron battlemechs—towering bipedal war-machines that stamped forward through the red mud on thick hydraulic pistons, their rotary thumpers already spinning.

They're dropping, his nervous system screamed. *They're dropping right on our heads, Marcus, get down—*

"Move it, grandpa!"

A young human courier on a hoverboard zipped past his elbow, swerving around the puddle at Marcus's feet, chewing melon-flavored gum. The kid didn't even glance back.

Marcus blinked. The mud of Kazahn washed away, replaced by the glare of a three-story holographic display advertising corporate bonds.

The vibration under his feet hadn't been an Orkish drop-cage. It had been the pneumatic coupling of a freight tram, latching its magnetic brake calipers onto the central rail three hundred meters down the concourse.

Marcus pressed his palms into his eyes until constellations of silver phosphor bloomed behind his eyelids. His body was trembling so violently that the change in his pocket jingled like small bells.

Safe, he told himself. *You are on Nimbus. You are thirty-four years old. You are on the mid-decks of Cloudspire. The war ended ten years ago. The treaty was signed. The Orks are on their side of the buffer. You are out of uniform.*

"You're out of uniform, Marcus," a second voice remarked dryly.

Sergeant Vane was sitting cross-legged on the lid of a grease-bin three feet away, field-stripping a phantom rail-carbine. Vane was forty, had a grey buzzcut, and had died in Marcus's arms behind the fuel depot on Ridge Nine when a stray flechette pierced his neck seal.

"You look like a vagrant," Vane said, blowing imaginary carbon dust from the bolt. "The Flotilla didn't spend a fortune wiring your spine to an optical firing computer so you could wander in the rain wearing a dead clerk's coat. Check your corners. We've got a tail."

"Leave me alone, Vane," Marcus rasped, keeping his head down as he began walking again, his work boots splashing through the shallow puddles.

"Can't do that, Sergeant," Vane replied calmly, falling into step two paces behind his right shoulder. The wet scrape of Vane's boots was silent to the world, but deafening to Marcus. "Three men trailing on the skybridge. Gangers. Scrappers from the lower ravines. They saw the silver in your neck."

Marcus didn't look. If you started checking corners every time your dead squad leader called out an ambush, the peacekeepers dragged you into a ward and pumped you full of neuro-blockers.

Besides, Marcus knew what real danger looked like. Real danger walked on two iron legs, ran on dirty diesel, and could stomp an armored carrier flat with a single hydraulic stride. Three men in the shadows were just noise.

He turned off the wide, brightly lit arterial boulevard and ducked into the shadowed maze of the city's service conduits.

Here, sixty meters beneath the pedestrian decks, the city revealed its bones. Heavy coolant lines the thickness of ancient redwoods ran along the ceilings, dripping condensation into rusty gutters. Steam hissed from valves, shrouding the narrow catwalks in warm, damp fog that smelled of sulfur and fried oil.

Marcus liked the dark. In the dark, the implant had fewer lights to mistake for targeting lasers. In the dark, his eyes didn't sting.

He stopped in the recessed alcove of an inactive ventilation turbine, resting his forehead against the vibrating steel.

He reached into the inner breast pocket of his coat and pulled out a small photograph sealed in creased plastic.

Elena was laughing in the picture. She was sitting on the wooden steps of their modest terraced cottage on the slopes of Landfall, her knees drawn up under a blanket, a mug of chicory tea steaming between her hands. Leaning against her side was Toby, five years old then, proudly holding up a crooked toy hopper he had carved from scrap pine with a plastic butter knife. Toby's front teeth were missing, and his grin was wide enough to swallow the valley.

Marcus touched the plastic with a rough, scarred thumb.

He remembered the kitchen. It was the last memory he had of them that wasn't soaked in terror.

It had been an ordinary Tuesday evening, four months after his discharge. Elena was drying the dishes, humming a half-remembered tune from the orbital ferries. Toby was asleep in the back bedroom under a patchwork quilt.

Elena had turned to put a ceramic serving platter into the cupboard. Her hands were wet. The platter slipped.

It didn't even fall six inches.

Before the dish could hit the floorboards, the combat implant had taken over. In less than forty milliseconds—faster than a human heart can finish a single beat—Marcus's body had moved without him.

He didn't remember standing up. He only remembered waking up to find his hand buried in the wall plaster, his forearm pinned across Elena's throat, and the shattered platter crushed to fine white dust inside his bare fist.

Elena hadn't screamed. She had just looked into his eyes—eyes whose pupils were dilated to black pools, shivering with targeting micro-tremors. A single tear had cut a clean line through the flour on her cheek.

And from the bedroom doorway, little Toby had stood clutching his wooden toy, staring at his father with eyes hollowed out by horror.

Marcus had dropped to his knees, gasping as if he had climbed out of a breached airlock.

He hadn't packed much. A change of clothes, his papers, and his discharge chits. He had waited until three in the morning, laid his Flotilla pension voucher on the wooden counter—enough credits to pay the lease and buy Toby new shoes every year until he was a grown man—and walked out the door.

A weapon did not belong in a house with children. You do not keep a live mine on the shelf next to the jam jars.

"You did the right thing," Aris whispered from the corner of the turbine housing. "You keep the rear echelon safe. That's doctrine."

"Shut up, Aris," Marcus choked out.

"He's not wrong about the tail, though," Vane's voice cut in, sharp and sudden. "On the catwalk above the coolant manifold. Twelve paces out. They're closing the trap."

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Sixty meters away, crouched behind the exhaust shroud of an air-intake scrubber, Jax lowered his thermal binoculars.

Beside him, Tessa checked the battery charge on her pneumatic capture carbine with a quiet click.

"Target confirmed," Jax whispered into his throat-mic. "Auxiliary turbine bay. It's Ward. Canvas coat, work boots, no weapon. He's leaning against the housing, shaking hard."

"Is he armed?" Tessa asked.

"Threw his service piece into a furnace three weeks ago," Jax replied. "Pockets are empty. But look at his spine on the thermal channel. Mother of mercy."

Tessa leaned over, peering at the secondary display. She let out a low breath.

Beneath the canvas coat, Marcus Ward's spine burned like a rod of white-hot magnesium. Intricate lines of silver traced outward from his vertebrae, wrapping around his ribs and pulsing with steady thermal leakage.

"The Mark-IV Synaptic Loom," Tessa murmured. "Pure naval skunkworks. Only eleven ever made. Built to let human infantry react as fast as mechanized walkers."

"And that's why the wolves are out," Jax said, glancing upward.

Across the gantry, four figures in piecemeal ballistic vests were slipping through the steam. They weren't soldiers; they were an Iron Fang cyber-salvage crew from the lower ravines—chop-shop cutthroats armed with heavy pneumatic taser-carbines and neural shock tethers, tipped off to an off-grid Flotilla veteran carrying four hundred thousand credits worth of military hardware under his skin.

"What about Stormwatch?" Tessa asked, glancing toward the foggy heights.

"They're above us," Jax muttered.

A hundred meters up, half-hidden in the swirling violet smog that rose from the ravines, the pitch-black hull of a Nimbus Rapid Response VTOL hovered in complete silence, its ducted lift-fans dialed to whisper-quiet station-keeping mode.

Stormdrinker, the ancient void dragon who roosted in the violent electrical squalls of Nimbus's upper atmosphere, was revered by the public as the 'Lightning Sage'—the majestic patron of Cloudspire. But behind closed doors, he was also the de facto head of the Sphere Research Center. Reclusive compared to his brother Goldheart down on Landfall, the dragon possessed an insatiable, terrifying thirst for knowledge that had its talons sunk into every sector of Flotilla space.

And the Nimbus Stormwatch was the sharpest talon of all. Their bleeding-edge armor, stealth aerostats, and proprietary weapons were sponsored directly by the SRC and the local megacorps. Because of that funding, Stormwatch was notorious for playing by their own cutthroat rules—more than happy to stage a quiet, questionable arrest under the guise of 'public safety quarantine' whenever the SRC flagged a rare piece of technology wandering the streets.

If the street gang didn't butcher Marcus for scrap, Stormwatch would bag him and haul him straight to an SRC neuro-lab for non-consensual dissection. That was why the Flotilla had chartered Corsairs: to get their veteran out alive and intact before either the wolves or the badge-wearing vultures closed in.

"Stay high," Jax instructed Tessa quietly. "Don't let Ward see us. If his combat governors trip, he won't know friend from foe. Cover him from the shadows."

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In the shadowed alcove, Marcus didn't hear the boots.

What he heard was the scrape of iron against concrete.

Marcus opened his eyes. The photograph of Elena and Toby slipped from his numb fingers, fluttering downward to land face-up in a shallow puddle of rainwater.

Ten paces ahead, emerging from the steam, were two men in greasy leather and scrap armor, holding heavy electric cattle-prods. A third was circling behind the turbine.

Ambuscade, the implant hummed against the base of his skull. *Three hostiles. Triangular envelopment.*

"Easy, soldier," the lead scrapper grinned, showing gold-capped teeth through the mist. "Just hold still. We're here to take a little weight off your spine."

To the gangers, Marcus was just a broken vagrant.

To Marcus, the world suddenly slowed until every drop of falling condensate hung in mid-air like dark glass.

The hum in his teeth vanished, replaced by the terrifying, crystal-clear silence of active combat. His peripheral vision flared with iridescent green vector lines. The silver filaments woven along his spinal cord burned with freezing fire.

He didn't make a decision. The machine made it for him.

The lead scrapper lunged with the shock prod. Marcus didn't dodge; he exploded forward like a released catapult spring, moving five meters in less than a quarter of a second.

His left palm struck the prod's shaft, snapping the fiberglass core clean in half. In the same fluid motion, his right palm drove upward into the scrapper's jaw.

The man flew backward through the steam, crashing into the coolant pipe before dropping limp into the gutter.

"Take him down!" the second scrapper yelled, swinging a heavy iron pipe.

Marcus ducked smoothly beneath the swing, pivoted on his heel, and drove his steel-toed boot into the side of the man's knee. The joint buckled with a sickening crack, and the ganger collapsed with a shriek of agony.

Behind them, up on the raised iron catwalk twenty paces away, a fourth scrapper had leaned over the railing, leveling a high-powered flechette rifle straight at Marcus's exposed back.

Marcus was looking away, his balance committed, blind to the rifle.

From high in the shadows of the ceiling duct, Tessa's suppressed carbine whispered with a silent pneumatic *pfft*.

A needle-thin tranquilizer dart struck the shooter squarely in the neck. The man stiffened, his fingers slipping from the trigger. His eyes rolled back, and he slumped quietly against the corrugated wall, sliding down into the shadows without firing a single shot.

The rifle clattered against the iron grating.

Marcus heard the metallic clatter and spun, assuming the fourth man had simply bolted. His eyes locked onto the third scrapper, who was cowering against the turbine housing.

Neutralize threat, the implant screamed through his marrow.

Marcus seized a heavy, two-meter scaffold pipe from the deck, ripped it from its rusted bracket, and swung it up over his shoulder like a sledgehammer, ready to bring it crashing down through the man's skull.

Smash the hatch. Seal the trench. Don't let them breach.

The scrapper raised trembling hands, shrieking in pure terror.

Marcus tightened his grip. The iron bar began its downward arc.

And then, cutting through the roaring static in his ears, a tiny sound rustled beneath his boot.

Marcus's eyes flicked downward.

There, in the filthy puddle, lay the photograph. Elena's smile. Toby's wooden hopper.

And in the silence of his skull, a small voice asked:

Daddy, are you coming home for dinner?

The iron pipe stopped.

It stopped three inches from the man's face. The displaced air ruffled the scrapper's hair.

Marcus stood frozen in the steam. His arms were shaking. The veins in his neck stood out like knotted cordage. The silver fire in his spine sputtered, flared, and then began to pulse with a chaotic, agonizing arrhythmia that felt like broken glass grinding against his bones.

"Toby..." he whispered.

He looked at the iron bar in his hands. Then he looked at the terrified kid cowering beneath it.

There were no Orkish battlemechs. There was no trench. There was only a terrified mugger in the rain, and Marcus Ward standing over him with an iron bar like a monster.

"Oh, God," Marcus choked out. "God... what am I doing?"

His fingers went limp. The heavy iron pipe clattered against the diamond-tread deck with a loud, ringing *CLANG*.

The terrified ganger didn't wait. He scrambled backward on all fours, scrambled to his feet, and vanished down the service corridor in blind panic.

Marcus sank to his knees in the puddle. His hands were trembling so violently he could barely scoop the wet photograph from the water. He pressed it to his chest, curled inward, and wept—dry, ragged sobs that shook his entire frame.

Above in the smog, the searchlights of the Stormwatch VTOL suddenly cut through the upper ventilation shafts. Sirens wailed in the distance. The gunshots and commotion had tripped municipal sensor grids.

Marcus scrambled to his feet, disoriented, clutching the picture inside his coat, and fled into the dark maintenance tunnels to get away from the noise.

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Twenty minutes later, Marcus stumbled out of the service labyrinth onto a quiet, covered promenade on Level Seventy-Two.

The neon here was subdued. Rain drummed steadily on corrugated plastic awnings that sheltered a row of humble market stalls. The air smelled of woodsmoke, roasting scallions, and boiling broth.

Marcus's legs were like lead. The adrenaline crash had hit him with the weight of an avalanche; his temperature had plummeted, his teeth were chattering, and the silver conduits in his neck ached with a dull, throbbing fever.

He collapsed onto a worn wooden stool beneath the awning of a small, open-front ramen stall tucked under an iron fire escape. He dropped his elbows onto the counter, buried his face in his hands, and tried to stop shaking.

"Two bowls of the pork broth, old friend," a calm, easy voice said from the stool beside him. "Extra noodles. Heavy on the scallions."

Marcus stiffened, his fingers twitching instinctively.

The man sitting on the adjacent stool didn't look like a soldier, a scrapper, or an officer. He looked like an ordinary, tired cargo worker in a faded brown leather jacket, with salt-and-pepper hair and calm grey eyes. He had his elbows propped comfortably on the counter, watching the old noodle chef drop a basket of noodles into boiling water.

"Rough night to be out without an umbrella," the man said mildly, not looking at Marcus directly. "Cloud deck's heavy tonight. Gets into the joints."

Marcus stared at him through bloodshot eyes. "I don't... I don't know you."

"Name's Jax," the man said smoothly.

The cook slid a massive, steaming ceramic bowl of rich amber broth, thick noodles, and roasted pork in front of Marcus, followed by a second bowl for Jax. Steam rose in a fragrant cloud between them.

"Eat up," Jax nudged the bowl an inch closer. "You're shivering like a wet stray. Broth is good for the shakes. Best medicine in the cluster."

Marcus hesitated. Every instinct told him to run, to find an airlock, to hide. But the warmth coming off the bowl was intoxicating, and his stomach was an empty, aching pit. He picked up a wooden spoon with a trembling hand, dipped it into the soup, and tasted it.

It was incredible. Rich, salty, savory, with a deep undertone of roasted garlic.

"Reminds me of Landfall," Jax said conversationally, slurping a mouthful of noodles. "Down in the river valleys. Cold mornings, red dirt under your fingernails. Best chicory tea in the system, if you ask me."

Marcus froze, his spoon hovering halfway to his mouth. "Landfall?"

"Yeah," Jax said, his tone entirely casual, as if chatting with a stranger on a ferry. "Had a buddy who lived out past Crossroads. Little terraced cottage with wooden steps. Used to tell me about his kid carving toy cargo hoppers out of scrap pine with a plastic butter knife. Said the boy carved it so crooked it looked like a potato with wings."

Marcus felt the breath leave his lungs in a sharp, quiet gasp. He looked at Jax.

Jax turned his head and met his gaze. There was no pity in the man's grey eyes, and no threat. There was only the quiet, steady understanding of someone who had seen the same horrors and survived them.

Marcus looked down into his bowl. Tears welled in his eyes and dripped into the steaming broth. He didn't ask how Jax knew. He didn't care. The warmth of the soup was already spreading through his chest, carrying with it a faint, sweet, medicinal numbness—a top-tier neuro-stabilizer formulated by naval surgeons to gently dampen overclocked synaptic loops.

Marcus ate. He ate like a starving man, spooning down the rich broth, chewing the pork, feeling the violent tremors in his hands begin to ease with every swallow.

When both bowls were empty, the old cook wordlessly cleared them away and set down a pot of hot tea.

Jax reached into his leather coat and pulled out a plain silver tin. He opened it, revealing a row of neatly rolled cigarettes.

"Got a smoke?" Jax asked, offering the tin. "Real Landfall leaf. Sun-cured. None of that synthetic chemical crap they sell on the upper decks."

Marcus reached out. His fingers, still stained with rust, took a cigarette.

Jax flicked an old brass lighter, holding the yellow flame steady. Marcus leaned in, drew the smoke into his lungs, and leaned back against the counter.

The tobacco was sweet, smelling of mountain clover and dried earth. And mixed into the fragrant leaf was a fast-acting respiratory sedative, sliding smoothly into his bloodstream to finish the work the broth had started.

Marcus exhaled a long plume of blue-grey smoke.

Across the counter, sitting on an empty vegetable crate in the alley rain, Corporal Aris was watching him. Aris didn't have a hole in his chest anymore. His uniform was clean. He smiled, gave a little two-finger salute, and dissolved softly into the drifting mist. Beside him, Sergeant Vane tipped his cap, turned, and walked away into the dark.

The ghosts were gone.

The sixty-cycle buzzing in Marcus's teeth ceased entirely. The constant, agonizing tension in his shoulders melted away. For the first time in ten years, the world was completely, beautifully quiet.

Marcus's eyelids grew heavy, like lead weights pulling him down. His head began to nod forward.

Jax moved smoothly, sliding an arm beneath Marcus's shoulders and supporting the veteran as he slumped against the counter. Jax leaned in close, his voice quiet, warm, and steady right beside Marcus's ear.

"You held the line, Sergeant," Jax whispered. "You held it until the war was over. But you're off the clock now."

Marcus breathed out, his forehead resting against Jax's worn leather sleeve. "The... the iron..."

"The iron's done falling, Marcus," Jax said softly. "The Flotilla chartered us to bring you in. No lockups. No salvage hounds. No cages. We've got a naval hospital frigate waiting at the high docks with surgeons who know how to turn that machinery down so you can live a normal life."

A single tear rolled down Marcus's cheek, catching the yellow light of the paper lanterns.

"And if all goes well," Jax murmured, "you're going home, Marcus. Elena and Toby are waiting."

A faint, peaceful smile touched the corner of Marcus's lips.

"Home..." he whispered.

He closed his eyes, and fell into a deep, dreamless sleep.

At the curb of the alley, a sleek, enclosed electric transport skiff glided to a silent stop in the rain. Tessa stepped out, opening the rear door and helping Jax lift the sleeping veteran onto the cushioned interior bench.

Jax turned back to the counter, dropped a generous stack of Flotilla credit chits beside the teapot, and nodded to the old cook. The cook nodded back in silent respect, pocketed the credits, and began wiping the counter.

Overhead, through the thick purple smog of Level Seventy-Two, the searchlights of the Nimbus Stormwatch VTOL swept blindly across the empty rooftops, hunting for a fugitive who was already gone.

And miles above the city, high in the wild, violet lightning of the storm-wells, the colossal form of Stormdrinker drifted through the jet stream. The great dragon circled once through the electrical clouds, his golden eyes gazing down upon the vast, glittering needle towers of Cloudspire, before turning his wings into the deep storm, leaving the quiet streets and the sleeping soldier behind.